

Equality, Diversity & Inclusion

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STFC Introduction to Astronomy Summer School 2026

Introductions



Connect
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Outline

- Jargon buster
- EDI as research culture
- Power, hierarchy and supervision
- Accessibility and disability beyond disclosure
- Overcoming personal biases and awareness gaps

Jargon buster

Protected characteristics

- Age
- Disability
- Gender reassignment
- Marriage / civil partnership
- Pregnancy / maternity
- Race / ethnicity
- Religion / belief
- Sex
- Sexual orientation

Direct and indirect discrimination

- Protections extended to associated individuals / groups.
- Extends protection against –ism / –phobic treatment to those with different identities.

Bullying, harassment and intimidation

- If you find something **harmful** or **hurtful**, it is important that you access support or signpost the recipient to available support.

Research culture

- EDI as “compliance” → EDI as “research culture”
- Does the workplace climate and its organisation enable everyone to contribute effectively?
- A poor research culture negatively impacts scientific quality, creativity and retention.

Everyone influences culture, even as junior / student researchers.

Reflective questions

- Have you ever stayed silent in a group discussion because you assumed everyone else understood something you didn't?
- Have you ever stayed silent in a group discussion because you felt inferior / didn't want to appear to challenge the perceived authority?
- Have you ever stayed silent in a group discussion because someone made a comment and the group's reaction (or lack of) made you feel unsafe or like an outsider?

Bystander

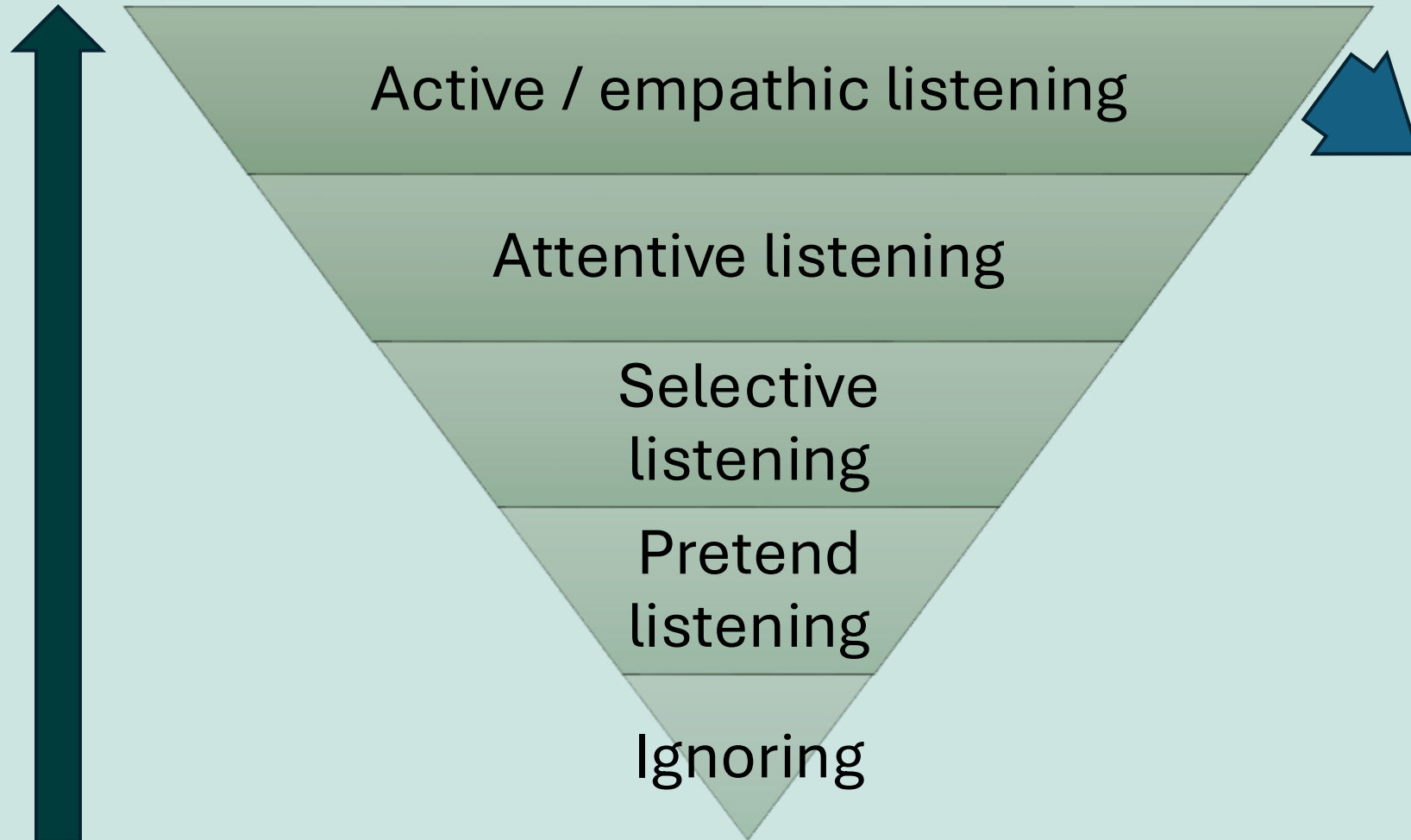
Perhaps your answer to one or more of the previous questions was “no”.

You're in a wonderful position where you're already able to fully contribute.

Ask yourself:

- Can I amplify overlooked contributions?
- Can I check in privately with anyone afterwards to see if they need support?
- Can I redirect any interruptions?
- Can I challenge potentially harmful assumptions by asking questions rather than making accusations?

Active listening



- Notice not only the words that are being said, but also the individual's emotional connection to them.
- Notice changes in behaviour.
- Notice unspoken reactions or disengagements.
- Listen with an intent to understand (both what is being said and where someone is coming from).

Practical examples

Scenario 1: someone is interrupted in a meeting or raises their hand while others butt-in

Quick solution:

“Can we pause a sec: I think X has had something to say”

Culture change:

- Approach the chair: “I’ve noticed that some people seem to talk over others during our meetings: how should I notify you that I wish to contribute?”
- Ask the meeting chair to clarify the meeting etiquette at the start of the next meeting: “Please could you clarify that at the next meeting. I think it could also benefit X.”

Practical examples

Scenario 2: a joke or comment in an open-plan office makes someone feel uncomfortable

Quick solutions:

“[mate], I don’t think that’s appropriate. Let’s keep things professional, ok?”

“I know what you’re getting at but it’s just not funny. Or appropriate.”

Culture change:

Speak with your group lead or EDI committee about professional conduct / boundaries awareness training or microaggressions self-defence training.

Practical examples

Scenario 3: a term used by a senior researcher in a research meeting makes someone junior feel uncomfortable

Quick solutions:

“Excuse me, the term [...] is better to use in this instance.”

Sometimes, you may be shocked and unable to respond promptly at the time. It may be easier to knock on someone’s door or drop them a quick email merely to say “I noticed you used the term [...] in the meeting earlier. It caught me off guard in the moment but I wanted to offer you the term [...] instead for future as the one you used could cause offence / is rather offensive.”

Practical examples

Scenario 3: a term used by a senior researcher in a research meeting makes someone junior feel uncomfortable

Culture change:

Speak with your group lead or EDI committee to make them aware that derogatory terms have been used and recommend an awareness raising campaign or training.

Speak with the person affected about reporting the incident. Are they aware of where to access support? Do they need their own feelings affirmed by a bystander? How would they like you to support them if something similar happens again?

The 4 Ds bystander model

Direct: “Let’s not interrupt”; “That’s not appropriate”

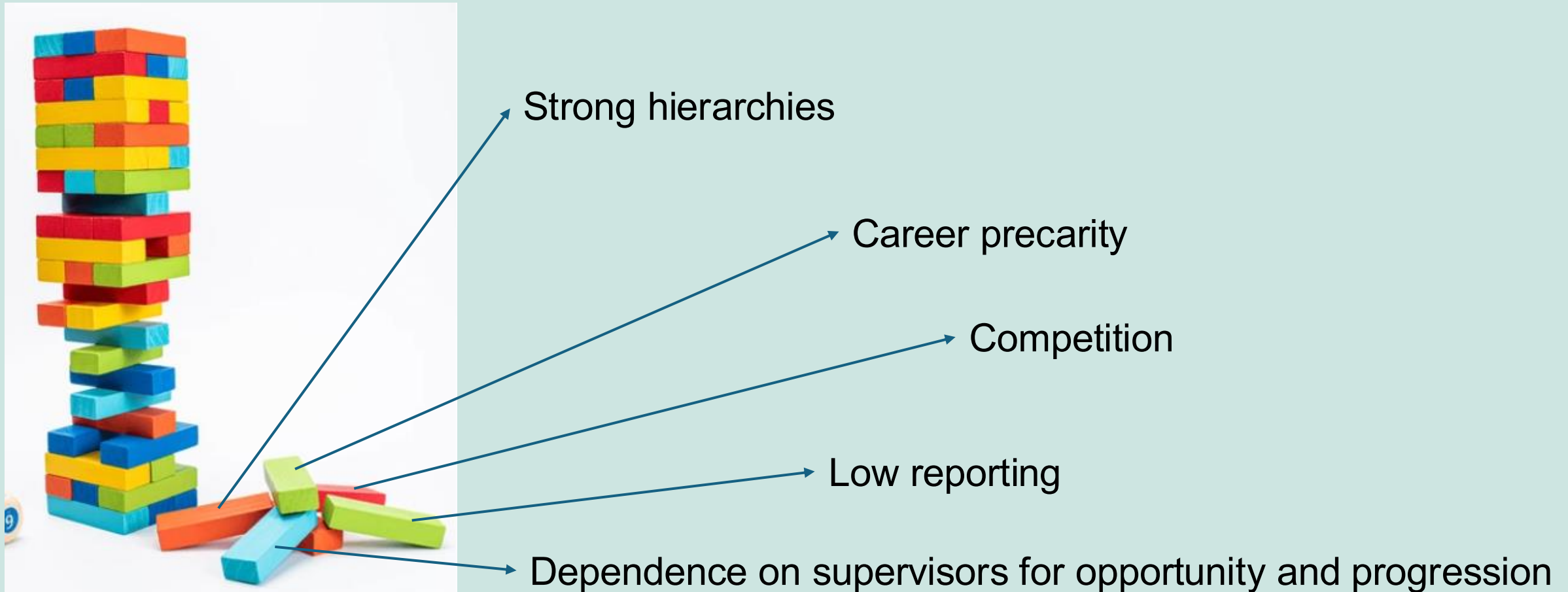
Distract: change the subject; ask a technical question; suggest a short break

Delegate: speak to a supervisor, organiser, convenor or chair

Delay: check in with the affected person afterwards.

Power, hierarchy & supervision

Certain characteristics of the research environment can enable problematic behaviour.

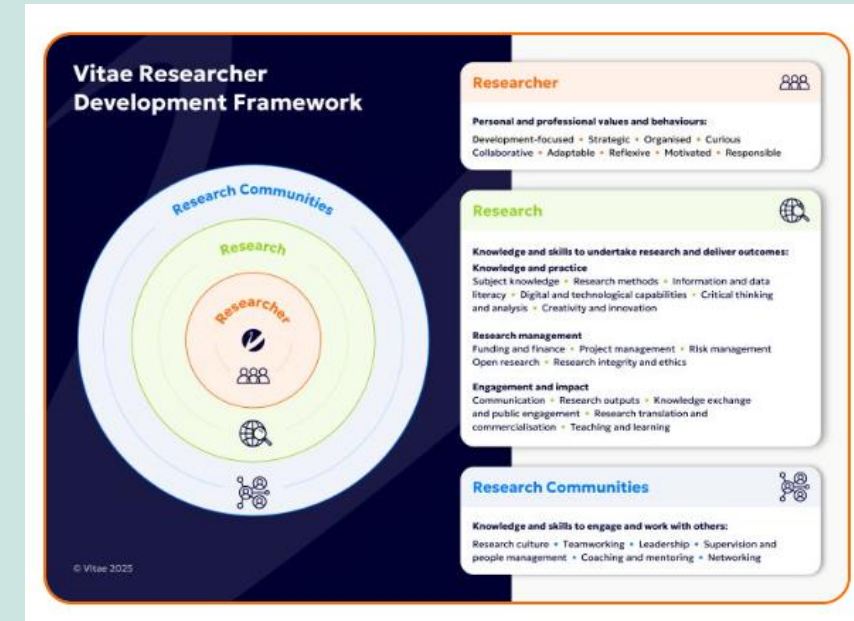


Your expectations as a PGR

One way to prevent hierarchies becoming problematic is by **building agency and awareness of expectations in research students / early career researchers.**

Vitae provide guides on [beginning your doctoral journey](#) and [the latter stages of doing a doctorate](#).

The **Researcher Development Concordat** provides guidance on [what is expected of you as a researcher](#) and what you can in turn expect from [your supervisor/manager](#), your [institution](#), and your [funder](#).



Vitae recommendations

- Your supervisor should set expectations with you: ensure these are workable.
- Discuss & agree on key issues (IP; research ethics; minimum contribution for authorship; travel & training budget etc).
- Be proactive & arrange formal supervisory meetings.
- Prepare agendas for meetings & prepare work for each meeting. Expect constructive criticism & feedback.
- Keep records of meetings and the actions arising and share these with your supervisor to ensure everyone is on the same page.
- Deal with issues as they arise (and before they build into anything bigger).

Mentorship

Peer mentoring

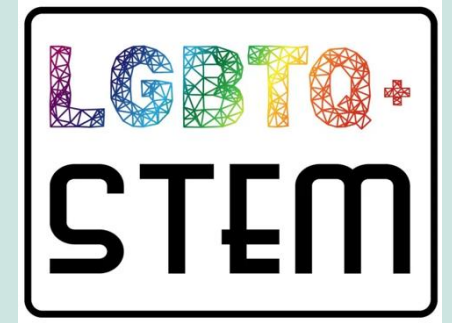
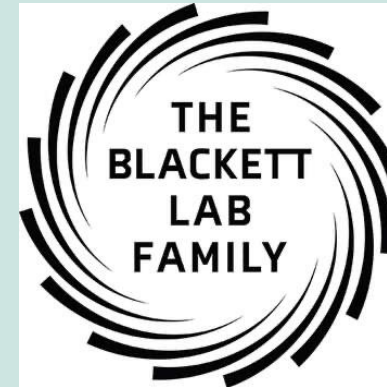
Postdocs and technicians

Demographic focussed support networks

LinkedIn; bluesky

Conferences, collaborators, and visitors

Approach potential mentors with specific goals and questions.



Support and report

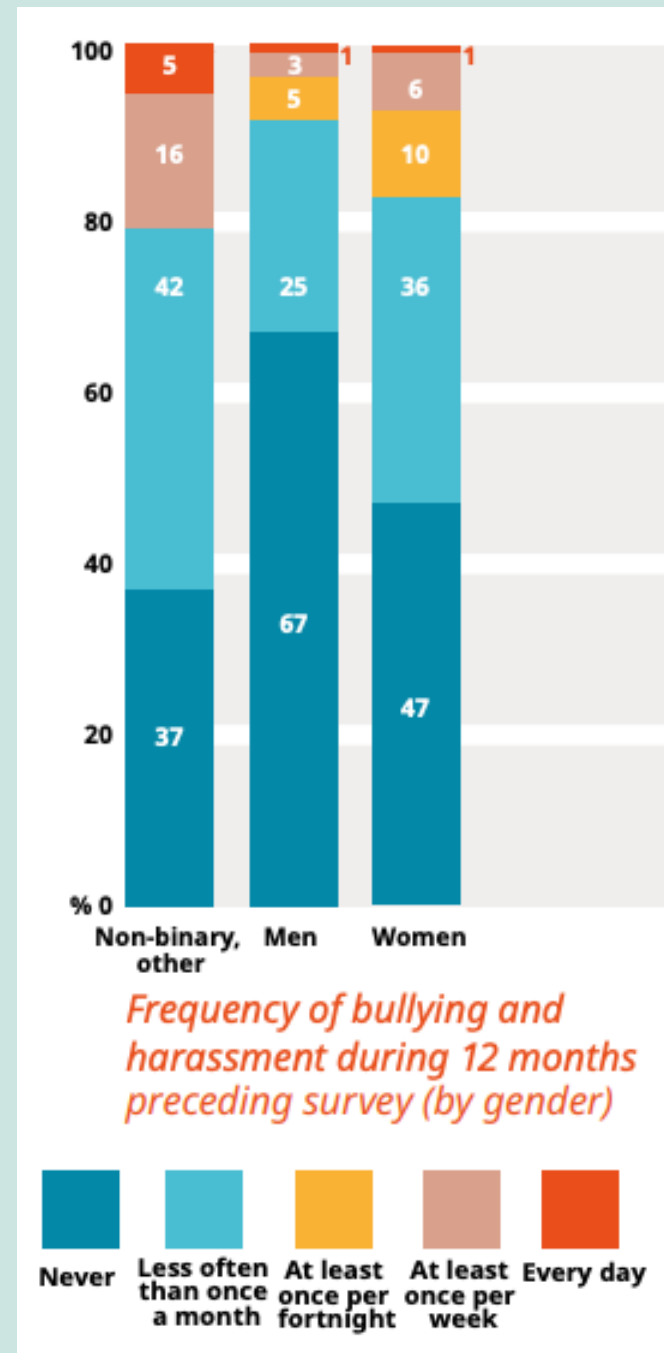
Sometimes, issues do arise.

We're working towards a culture where hurtful / harmful comments or actions can be challenged and corrected quickly and effectively. But we're not there yet.

Your institution / university should have Support and Report pages for you to raise issues.

Conferences and journals have codes of conduct, with recommended points of contact.

[The 1752 Group](#); [21 percent group](#)



Disability...

A disability is defined as a physical or mental impairment that has substantial and long-term impact.

May be temporary (e.g. a broken ankle) or life-long (e.g. hearing impairment).

The disabling effects may be permanent, temporary, or variable (e.g. cancer; OCD, ME).

Support routes are typically based on the **medical model** of disability in which individuals *have* disabilities.

Accessible design uses the **social model** of disability in which individuals *are disabled* by barriers.

Person-first and identity-first language are both used within disabled communities. Be open to correction.

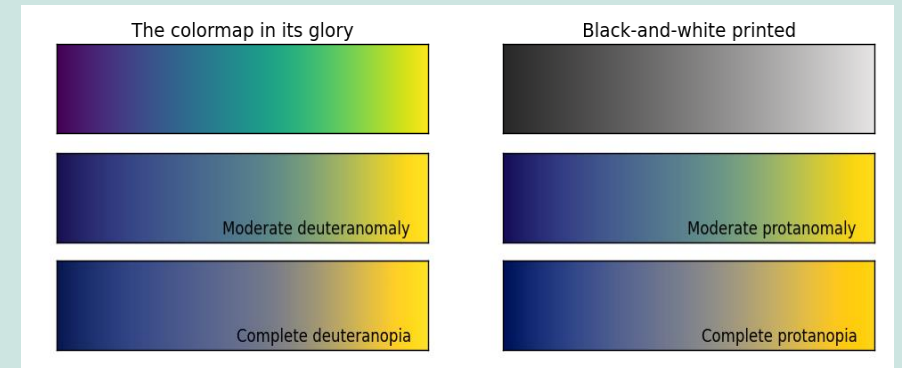
...and accessibility

Aim to remove disabling barriers to access and inclusion through accessible design.

Accessibility benefits more people than the group it was originally designed for.

Common considerations:

- [colourblind friendly colour maps in matplotlib](#)
- hybrid participation / quiet participation
- written agendas, circulation of meeting materials, clear action points



Individual reasonable adjustments then sit atop these accessible design features.

Reasonable adjustments

Your university / institute will have a team / department to discuss any access needs you have.

Your supervisor may need to refer you to this in the first instance.

You should not need a formal diagnosis to start accessing support.

[Disabled Students Allowance](#)

IOP's [Accessibility Fund](#)

Examples

“I was struggling with processing spoken feedback and remembering verbal instruction during long group meetings”

“I was provided typed summary emails containing bullet-pointed checklists of actions and deadlines from my supervisor within 24 hours of our meetings.”

“I was struggling with a physical health condition that caused intense pain when sitting for more than 45 minutes at a time.”

“I was provided a specialised ergonomic chair and sit/standing desk. My supervisor supported me to break up our meetings with breaks when I needed them.”

“I needed a quiet space to analyse my data and write up my paper without interruption.”

“I was provided a designated quiet hot-desk in a separate room, a budget for high quality noise-cancelling headphones, and permission to work from home two days a week.”

“I was being overly self-critical and feeling down during the luteal phase of my menstrual cycle”

“I was provided weekly 1:1 meetings with my supervisor, with feedback prescribed in a ‘stop, start, continue’ format which enabled me to recognise my growth as well as receive constructive feedback.”

Personal biases & awareness gaps

No one is expecting you to be an EDI expert.

Instead, in their bid to improve research culture, UKRI expect all researchers – including you – to take an active role in EDI.

This requires continuous professional development (CPD).

- Sign-up for that training you're offered;
- attend that seminar or workshop;
- sit in on EDI committee meetings;
- read the book / listen to the podcast / watch the TV series or film that's being discussed.

Exposure yourself to different perspectives to **understand where your personal biases and awareness gaps are.**

Your decisions have impacts

You may wish to ask yourself:

- Who can safely access this conference / workshop I'm organising? Who is it "not for" and what is the cost to them?
- Whose ancestral land am I accessing to use this observatory?
- Who am I citing? Where (globally) are they based?
- Who funds my research? How do I ensure they benefit? Should they?
- Who uses / benefits from the software I write / develop?
- Who shares the skies I'm viewing? Who / what shares the dark I'm trying to access?

A few cautionary tales

[Mauna Kea.](#)

Driverless cars not coded to recognise “jaywalkers”. ([access via Box of Broadcasts](#) - SSO login required)

[Automatic hand dryers with sensors that only recognise pale skin tones.](#)

Voice activated tech which only registers speech in lower pitches. (Search for “Invisible Women” by Caroline Criado Perez in your campus library).

Help is at hand:

- Research ethics
- Public engaged research
- EDI consultants and demographic-based networks

Summary

Jargon buster

Prescribe bullying, intimidation and harassment in terms of the hurt or harm it causes.

EDI as research culture

Understand your role in establishing the culture of your workplace / study spaces; Practical bystander examples.

Power, hierarchy and supervision

Appreciate how certain aspects of academic structures could enable problematic behaviours; Recall where to access guidance on what is expected of you as a PhD student; Recall where to access mentorship and further support.

Accessibility and disability beyond disclosure

Appreciate how the social model of disability differs from the medical model; Practical accessibility considerations.

Overcoming personal biases and awareness gaps

Remain open to learning about others' perspectives and engage in consultative research practices.